IT Support Engineer Interview Questions & Answers

Preparing for an IT Support / Desktop Support Role

10) What is PST and OST?

PST

PST = Personal Storage Table

It is an Outlook data file used to store emails, contacts, calendars, etc., locally.

OST

OST = Offline Storage Table

It is a local synchronized copy of mailbox data used with Exchange/Microsoft 365 accounts.

Simple difference:
PST = personal/local archive or exported Outlook data
OST = offline synchronized copy of the mailbox

11) What is O365 and its licenses?

Microsoft 365 (formerly Office 365) is Microsoft's cloud-based productivity platform.

It provides services such as:

- Outlook, Word, Excel, PowerPoint
- Teams, OneDrive, SharePoint
- Exchange Online

Licenses vary depending on the organization's requirements. Examples include:

- Microsoft 365 Business Basic
- Microsoft 365 Business Standard
- Microsoft 365 Business Premium
- Microsoft 365 E3 / E5

12) What is the maximum size limit of PST?

The default maximum PST/OST size is generally **50 GB**.

13) How many partitions can be created?

It depends on the partitioning scheme.

MBR:

- Maximum **4 primary partitions**
- Or **3 primary + 1 extended partition** (extended partition can contain logical drives)

GPT:

- Windows commonly supports up to **128 partitions** on a GPT disk.

> ***Interview answer:*** *"MBR supports 4 primary partitions, while GPT supports up to 128 partitions in Windows."*

14) How to backup rules in Outlook?

For **classic Outlook**, you can export rules using the Rules and Alerts option.

Steps:

1. Open Outlook.
2. Go to **File** → **Manage Rules & Alerts**.
3. Click **Options**.
4. Select **Export Rules**.
5. Save the `.rwz` file.

To restore, use **Import Rules**.

15) What is POP3 and IMAP?

Both are email protocols.

POP3: Downloads emails from the mail server to the device.
Default port: 110 | *Secure POP3:* 995

IMAP: Synchronizes emails between the mail server and the email client.
Default port: 143 | *Secure IMAP:* 993

Simple difference: POP3 = mainly download mail | IMAP = synchronize mail

16) How do you fix a slowness issue?

I follow a systematic troubleshooting process:

1. Check Task Manager (CPU, RAM, and Disk usage).
2. Check available disk space & startup applications.
3. Check background processes, Windows updates, & antivirus scans.

17) How to map a printer?

Network printer:

1. Go to **Settings** → **Bluetooth & devices** → **Printers & scanners**.
2. Select **Add device**.
3. Add the printer by hostname/IP if required.
4. Install the appropriate driver and print a test page.

For a shared printer, connect via: `\\PrintServer\PrinterName`

18) Difference between Network Printer and Wireless Printer

Network Printer: Connected to the organization's network, commonly through Ethernet or Wi-Fi, accessible by network users.

Wireless Printer: Communicates wirelessly, usually through Wi-Fi.

Important: A wireless printer can also be a network printer.

19) What are Ping, Tracert and Telnet?

Ping: Checks whether a device is reachable over the network and measures response time (e.g., `ping 192.168.1.1`).

Tracert: Shows the network path/hops between your computer and the destination (e.g., `tracert google.com`).

Telnet: Can be used to test whether a specific TCP port is reachable (e.g., `telnet 192.168.1.10 443`).

20) Default port numbers

Standard Ports:

- SMTP: 25
- HTTP: 80 | HTTPS: 443
- POP3: 110 | IMAP: 143
- RDP: 3389 | DNS: 53

Secure Email Ports:

- SMTP submission: 587
- SMTPS: 465
- POP3S: 995
- IMAPS: 993

21) What is Subnet Mask?

A subnet mask determines which part of an IP address represents the network and which part represents the host.

22) What is SMTP?

SMTP stands for Simple Mail Transfer Protocol.

It is used to **send emails** from an email client to a mail server and between mail servers.

Common ports:

- 25 – server-to-server SMTP
- 587 – authenticated mail submission
- 465 – implicit TLS SMTP

23) What are IP Classes?

Traditional IPv4 classful addressing has five classes:

Class	Range	Typical use
A	1–126	Very large networks
B	128–191	Medium networks
C	192–223	Smaller networks
D	224–239	Multicast
E	240–255	Experimental

Interview tip: Modern networks generally use **CIDR**, rather than relying on traditional Class A/B/C boundaries.

24) What is DLP?

DLP stands for Data Loss Prevention.

It is a security technology used to prevent sensitive or confidential data from being leaked, copied, uploaded or shared without authorization (e.g., blocking an employee from copying confidential files to a USB drive).

25) Types of Network Topology

Common network topologies are: **1. Bus, 2. Star, 3. Ring, 4. Mesh, 5. Tree, 6. Hybrid**

26) Explain OSI Model

The OSI model has **7 layers**. Mnemonic to remember: *"Please Do Not Throw Sausage Pizza Away"*

Layer	Name	Example
7	Application	HTTP, DNS, SMTP
6	Presentation	Encryption, formatting
5	Session	Session management
4	Transport	TCP, UDP
3	Network	IP, Router
2	Data Link	MAC, Switch
1	Physical	Cable, Fiber

> ***Simple interview answer:*** *"OSI is a seven-layer model used to understand how network communication works and troubleshoot network problems layer by layer."*

27) What is Encryption?

Encryption converts readable data into an unreadable format using a cryptographic process. Only someone with the appropriate key can decrypt the data (e.g., HTTPS uses encryption to protect traffic).

28) What is Teams?

Microsoft Teams is a collaboration and communication platform providing chat, audio/video calls, meetings, screen sharing, file sharing, and Microsoft 365 integration.

29) What is Public IP?

A public IP address is routable on the public internet, generally assigned by an ISP.

30) What is Lease IP?

A lease IP is temporarily assigned by a DHCP server to a device for a specific lease duration. When it expires, the device renews it.

31) What is DORA Process?

DORA is the process used by DHCP to assign an IP address:

- **D – Discover:** Client searches for a DHCP server.
- **O – Offer:** DHCP server offers an IP address.
- **R – Request:** Client requests the offered IP.
- **A – Acknowledge:** DHCP server confirms the assignment.

Easy way to remember: Discover → Offer → Request → Acknowledge

32) What is MAC Address?

MAC stands for Media Access Control address. It is a hardware address used at the Data Link layer (Layer 2). Example: `00-1A-2B-3C-4D-5E`

Key distinction: MAC = Layer 2 | IP = Layer 3

33) What is SLA?

SLA stands for Service Level Agreement. It defines the agreed level of service between a service provider and customer/business (includes response time, resolution time, availability, support hours, priority levels).

Example: A P1 incident may have a response SLA of 15 minutes.

34) What is NAS?

NAS stands for Network Attached Storage. It is a storage device connected to a network that allows authorized users/computers to access shared files (commonly used for Centralized storage, File sharing, Backup, and Media management).

★ Quick Interview Revision

Remember these especially well:

DNS → Name to IP	**DHCP** → Automatically gives IP
Gateway → Path to other networks	**Firewall** → Allows/blocks traffic
Proxy → Intermediary for internet traffic	**PST** → Outlook personal data file
OST → Offline synchronized mailbox data	**POP3** → Download mail
IMAP → Synchronize mail	**SMTP** → Send mail
DORA → DHCP IP assignment process	**MAC** → Layer 2 address